



CLOSE AIR SUPPORT

OPERATION CEDAR FALLS

American ground troops were committed to a war against communist guerrillas in South Vietnam in 1965. US commander General William Westmoreland adopted an aggressive strategy, directing forces in large-scale “search and destroy” operations in guerrilla-controlled areas. Operation Cedar Falls in January 1967 exemplified the successes and failures of this approach.

Operation Cedar Falls was directed against the Iron Triangle, a guerrilla stronghold 40km (25 miles) from the South Vietnamese capital Saigon. Over many years the guerrillas had fortified the area with a complex system of tunnels protected by boobytraps and concealed firing positions. The Americans planned to encircle and destroy the guerrillas in a “hammer and anvil” operation. Troops along the southwest side of the Triangle would be the “anvil”, blocking the guerrillas’ escape as they were hit by the “hammer” – forces attacking from the north and east. The plan relied on helicopters to lift infantry swiftly into their combat positions, thereby bypassing difficult forested terrain and avoiding possible ambushes to convoys on roads. Helicopter gunships were not yet available, but the infantry received supporting firepower from tactical bombers, fixed-wing gunships, and artillery firebases.

The operation began on 8 January with the placing of the “anvil” forces, including elements of the South Vietnamese Army. One of the first objectives was to secure the village of Ben Suc, considered a hotbed of guerrilla activity. A flight of 60 helicopters zoomed in at treetop level and landed an entire American infantry battalion at positions around the village, which was then occupied with only light casualties. Other airmobile formations and mechanized infantry executed the “hammer” element of the operation over the following days. Travelling in M113 armoured personnel carriers, the

mechanized infantry were protected against the antipersonnel mines and sniping that took such a toll on soldiers on foot patrol. Newly introduced Rome ploughs, designed for heavy land-clearance, carved swathes through the jungle, while specially trained and equipped soldiers were sent in to search the dark maze of tunnels. These “tunnel rats” found caches of weapons and munitions, uniforms, food dumps, and an abundance of documents valuable to US intelligence.

DESTRUCTION OF RESOURCES

The Americans and South Vietnamese allies went on to render the Iron Triangle unusable for guerrilla forces. Tunnels were filled with acetylene gas and blown up, while much of the area was sprayed from the air with Agent Orange herbicide, poisoning forest and agricultural land. The peasant population was evacuated at gunpoint to refugee camps and Ben Suc was totally destroyed, the buildings burned, then flattened by bulldozers. But the objective of locating and destroying communist soldiers largely failed. The lightly equipped guerrillas were expert at concealment and slipped through the US cordon. The combination of the Americans’ firepower and mobility allowed them to clear populated regions of guerrillas – but at the cost of devastating the peasant society that sustained them and laying waste to land US troops were deployed to defend. What American forces could not do was bring enemy formations to decisive combat and destroy them.